UNIT 4: STRATEGIES FOR SUCCESS

PART II: OBTAINING AND RETAINING WORK

TOPIC 4: JOB INTERVIEWS

Lesson 1

Topic OBJECTIVE: The learner will:

- Understand the structure and expectations of a professional job interview

Topic OUTCOME: The learner will:

- Have the knowledge and skills to prepare for and successfully complete a job interview

Topic ACTIVITIES:

Large Group Discussion

Objective: Students will learn about the purpose and structure of a job interview.
Time: 20 minutes
Materials: Handouts: **"Ready, Set, Go For It," "Ready Self Check Sheet,"** and **"Go For It Self Check Sheet,"** chart paper/markers for **"Interview Tools List"**

Explain to students that obtaining a job interview is an accomplishment in itself. An interview means that the employer thinks you may be a good match for the job and wants to meet you in-person. Furthermore, explain that in many cases, employers judge candidates by their promptness, dress, and communication skills at a job interview.

Discuss what happens before an interview — Ask students what they think happens at a job interview, and how they should prepare for it. Have them web or brainstorm ideas on the worksheet **"Ready, Set, Go For It."** Ask them to add ideas after reading **"Ready Self Check Sheet"** to complete the web.

Discuss what happens during the interview — Ask students to read the worksheet **"Go For it Self Check Sheet"** (as a group if comfortable, or individually). Ask what some of the feelings are that one might have during a job interview (nervous, proud, scared, unsure, excited), and create a list together of "tools" that would be good to have (i.e., eye contact, neat appearance, firm handshake, confident smile, careful listening, speaking loudly and clearly (no slang, etc.).

Kinesthetic Activity — Mock Job Interviews

Objective: Students will understand the meaning of "professional appearance" expected for a successful job interview.
Time: 20 minutes
Materials: Handout: **"Dressing for Job Interviews,"** professional clothing from various sources, magazines, scissors

Instructors, please prepare students for the next lesson ahead of time by asking them to put together a professional-looking outfit for a mock interview for the next class. Ask students to choose the clothes that they believe would be appropriate for a job interview. If this is not possible, have youth choose pictures from magazines that represent appropriate/inappropriate outfits for an interview. Often time, clothes can be donated or borrowed from organizations such as "Dress for Success," "Attire for Hire" or other similar clothing donation organizations. If this is not possible, bring in a selection of magazines that can be cut up for collages.

Pass out the **"What to Wear for Job Interviews"** handout. Go over any basics that students may need or have questions about (i.e. how to tie a tie, choosing matching clothing items, handshake/eye contact, ironing, etc.). Explain that participants will wear these professional outfits for the next session, where mock interviews will take place.

Make a list of suggestions for the students of places they can go to get an interview outfit, such as: a consignment shop like Plato's Closet, or a used clothing shop like Goodwill, look for local sales, or try **www.freecycle.org**. Make sure students know their correct sizes for tailored items before purchasing clothes.

Technical (Mass CIS)/Research

Objective: Students will be able to locate job advertisements and employment information online. Students will be able to link their personal skill, interests and experience with potential job opportunities.

Time: 15 minutes

Materials: Computers with internet connection, paper, pens/pencils, **Mass CIS** note cards with log-in information

Ask students to find a classified job advertisement online to use as a basis for their mock interview. Help students choose one that seems to match their skills and experience. Have them write down information about it, and read company information online to familiarize themselves with their (mock) potential employer. If no "Help Wanted" ads seem appropriate, design a short mock job opening for the student. If there is time, check the **Mass CIS** Interview section (click under **"Job Search"** heading on the left side of the homepage) for more tips on interviewing.

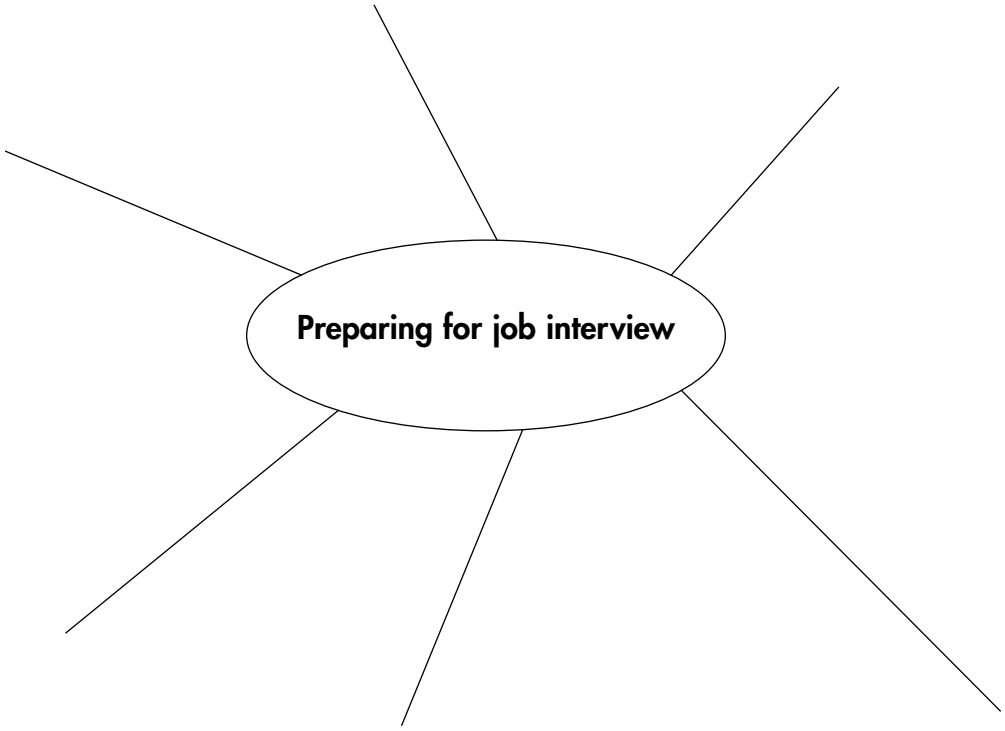
Get the Job: Ready, Get Set, Go for It — Interview Prep

Ready —

You've done an effective job search and have lined up an interview. You have written down the time, date, place and directions. What else do you have to do to prepare?

Step 1: Fill in the web with your ideas, and then ask your instructor for the Ready Self-Check Sheet.

Step 2: Add to your web ideas you didn't think of.



Ready Self Check Sheet

1. Get and fill out the job application. Have someone else check it for spelling and completeness.

2. Line up reliable transportation.

    - If you're getting a ride from someone, make sure they plan to get you to your appointment at least 10 minutes early. Tell the driver that this date is very important to you and that you really appreciate her helping you. Offer to pay her gas, watch her children, cook a meal or do something else to show your gratitude.

    - If you're driving yourself, check the day before to make sure you have enough gas.

    - If you're talking the bus, take the same bus when you pick up the application so you're certain of what bus to take connections to make, cost and the time it takes to get there.

3. Think about the skills you have. Compare your skills to the skills needed to do the job.

4. Learn something about the company or the job. Make a list of *5-7* questions to ask. Don't ask too much about breaks and vacations. Do ask about the company's newest product or what the interviewer thinks what characteristics help an employee be successful.

5. Practice answering questions that are often asked at interviews. If you role-play your answers with a friend or out loud in front of a mirror, you'll probably feel less nervous during the real interview.

6. Bring a pen or pencil, social security card, completed job application and your list of questions.

Adapted from Merging Two Worlds 2003 Chapter 4 Lesson *7*

MEN

	DO WEAR	DON'T WEAR
Hair:	Clean Combed, or pulled back	Dirty Unkempt/messy
Clothes:	Clean collared shirts — white, solid color Dress pants — dark color, fitted Professional looking tie (no cartoon characters, etc.) Sweater/jacket/blazer	T-shirts, sweat shirts, jersey, or hoodie Jeans, shorts Baggy clothes Dirty or stained clothes
Shoes:	Dark dress shoes — black, brown or rust Dark socks	Sneakers Timberlands (unless it's a construction interview)
Accessories:	Watch Fingernails are short and clean	Any visible piercing Big necklaces with pendants Chain wallets with the chain dangling down the leg Strong cologne or aftershave

WOMEN

	DO WEAR	DON'T WEAR
Hair:	Clean Combed or pulled back	Dirty Messy/unkempt
Clothes:	Skirts at or below the knee Dress pants Professional blouse or collared shirt Sweater/jacket/blazer Scarves	Mini skirts Skirts or dresses with wild patterns See through items or material that shimmers Exposed navels Cleavage
Shoes:	Enclosed toe professional shoes (pumps or flats) Heels that are an inch or two high	Very high heels that you cannot walk in comfortably Flip Flops
Accessories:	One simple pair of earrings Short clean nails painted without designs	Very large/hanging earrings More than one pair of earrings Nose rings, tongue rings or facial piercing Long acrylic nails — keep them short Unusual nail color or designs — keep nails painted one color Heavy make-up, try lighter

GO FOR IT Self Check Sheet

1. **Relax.** Take a couple of deep breaths. Think about what skills you have and how you could use them in this job.

2. **Treat everyone with respect.** The receptionist, the janitor, and the boss. What is your opinion of a person who treats you with respect? Disrespect?

3. **Shake hands and look at the person while you are talking or while she is talking.** Follow the conversation, think about what the other person is saying, don't just wait for your turn to talk.

4. **Show a cooperative, professional attitude.** BE enthusiastic. Don't bad-mouth former employers. Don't tell jokes. Don't use rude language. Don't talk about personal problems.

5. **Write a short thank you letter** to the person who interviewed you. In a sentence or two, express gratitude and interest.

*****And Always Remember To Turn Off Your Cell Phone*****

Adapted from Merging Two Worlds, 2003

Lesson 2

Topic OBJECTIVE: The learner will:

- Understand the structure and expectations of a professional job interview

Topic OUTCOME: The learner will:

- Have the knowledge and skills to prepare for and successfully complete a job interview

Topic ACTIVITIES:

(Depending on group size, this lesson may span more than one class period.)

Large Group Discussion

Objectives:
- Students will be familiar with typical expectations and questions asked in a professional job interview.
- Students will reflect upon, and write their own individual answers to these questions.

Time: 20 minutes

Materials: Handouts: "Things to do During and After a Job Interview" and "Common Interview Questions"

Hand out the "Things to do During and After a Job Interview" sheets, and ask students to discuss ways in which a potential employee can impress a potential employer. Review with students the "Questions the Interviewer May Ask" sheet. Ask students to carefully answer each question on the handouts, in order to prepare for the mock interview.

Kinesthetic Activity — Mock Job Interviews

Objective: Students will participate in a mock professional job interview, in order to practice and prepare for a genuine interview.

Time: 10 minutes per interview

Materials: Handout: "Common Interview Questions"

Wearing a professional outfit (planned from the previous class), and interviewing for a job of their choice, students should participate in a mock job interview. The instructor should "stand in" for an employer, choosing a few of the questions from the "Common Interview Questions" handouts and giving written or face-to-face feedback (privately) after the "mini-interview." If appropriate, other students can observe the interviews and give encouragement and feedback.

After the student's interview, ask them to re-read "Things to do During and After a Job Interview," and put a check next to the things they feel they did well, and circle the things that they feel they may have forgotten to do or need to improve on.

The Interview: THINGS TO DO DURING AND AFTER A JOB INTERVIEW

Things to Do During a Job Interview:

How you conduct yourself during a job interview determines how well the interview may go and if you are hired.

1. Maintain positive eye contact. Remain attentive during an interview.
2. Always give a firm handshake.
3. Speak clearly and audibly so that you can be understood and heard.
4. Always present a pleasant attitude, be friendly and smile.
5. Clearly express your job goals and qualifications.

Things to Do After a Job Interview:

How you conclude your job interview is just as important as how you conduct yourself during the interview. After the interview, there are some very important things you should do. They are as follows:

1. Stand up, shake the interviewer's hand firmly. Thank the interviewer for taking time for your interview.
2. Tell the interviewer you are interested in the job and the company, never assume the interviewer knows you want the job.
3. Make sure you know what the "next step" is — will they contact you via phone or mail/e-mail, or are you to contact them?

Adapted from Merging Two Worlds, 2003

The Interview: QUESTIONS INTERVIEWERS MAY ASK

Physical Appearance:

First impressions are important and your physical appearance can speak volumes. Make sure you are clean, neat, and professionally and suitably dressed for the interview. Take care to make your appearance flattering and professionally appealing.

There are standard questions that you should anticipate prior to any interview. Practice your responses ahead of time. Listen carefully to the questions asked and impress the interviewer with your careful and complete responses.

Tell me about yourself.

The interviewer isn't looking for a recounting of our whole life's history. He/she is generally seeking to discover what you consider your greatest asset for this particular job. You should talk about work and educational experiences which prove you can do the job, and be prepared to recount your strongest skills

Why are you interested in joining our company?

Demonstrate that you have researched the company. Show how your career goals relate to the company. Suggest how you might work toward the resolution of problems. Indicate your enthusiasm about this particular company and its products.

What courses did you particularly enjoy?

What qualifications do you have for this job?

Where do you see yourself in five years?

Why should I hire you?

What is your greatest strength?

What do you enjoy doing in your spare time?

What questions do you have?

Be prepared — this question always arises. Always ask at least one question. Bring along a written list of questions and ask the ones which were not covered in the interview. Ask about the hierarchy of the organization (to whom would you report?) and about the other people with whom you would be working.

You may wish to ask questions about the rest of the interview process: What is the next step in the decision-making process regarding this job? How many other candidates are being interviewed for the position?

When can I expect to hear about your decision?

Adapted from Merging Two Worlds, 2003